

# MISSION REBUILD™

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## MISSION REBUILD™ Resource List

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*From Army to Civilian: Building Structure, Purpose,  
Identity & Financial Stability After Service*

# MISSION REBUILD™ Resource List

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## Curated Tools, Books, Podcasts & Programs for Veteran Transition

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*How to use this list: Don't try to read everything at once. Pick one book from the section most relevant to where you are right now. Bookmark the VA links and tools you need. Return to this list as you progress through the course.*

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## BOOKS

### Veteran Transition & Identity

1. **"The Veteran's Transition Handbook" by Bart Astor** — Comprehensive practical guide covering everything from benefits to career transition. Covers the logistics of getting out without sugarcoating the challenges.
2. **"Once a Warrior — Wired for Life" by Dr. Lawrence Levin** — Written by a former Army Ranger turned psychologist. Explores the neurological and psychological rewiring that combat does to a soldier and how to leverage those traits in civilian life.
3. **"The Mission Continues" by Eric Greitens** — Former Navy SEAL and Rhodes Scholar on finding mission and purpose after military service. Practical and direct. Honest about how hard the transition is.
4. **"Tribe: On Homecoming and Belonging" by Sebastian Junger** — War correspondent explores why veterans struggle to reintegrate. One of the most important books for understanding why civilian life can feel hollow after service. Short, fast read.
5. **"Redeployment" by Phil Klay** — Fiction. National Book Award winner. A collection of short stories that captures the disorientation of coming home more accurately than most non-fiction. Read this if you want to feel less alone.
6. **"The Hardest Work" by Travis Switalski** — A Marine's account of the identity crisis after service and the work required to build something new. Written veteran-to-veteran.
7. **"Make Your Bed" by Admiral William H. McRaven** — 10 lessons from Navy SEAL training applied to building a better life. Short and motivating. Gets passed around for a reason.

8. **"Leadership Strategy and Tactics" by Jocko Willink** — Not specifically about transition, but directly applies military leadership thinking to civilian leadership contexts. Practical and no-fluff.
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## Personal Finance & Wealth Building

1. **"The Total Money Makeover" by Dave Ramsey** — The classic debt elimination framework. Baby steps approach. Some veterans find it too conservative, but the debt payoff methodology is solid and the discipline aligns with military thinking.
  2. **"I Will Teach You to Be Rich" by Ramit Sethi** — Younger, more aggressive take on personal finance. Focuses on automating your money system, not cutting out lattes. Better for veterans who want to build wealth, not just survive.
  3. **"The Millionaire Next Door" by Thomas J. Stanley** — Research-based look at how actual millionaires build wealth. Spoiler: it's not glamorous. Validates the military frugality mindset as a wealth-building asset.
  4. **"Rich Dad Poor Dad" by Robert T. Kiyosaki** — The foundational financial literacy mindset book. Skip some of the hyperbole, absorb the framework: assets vs. liabilities, building cash flow, not just a paycheck.
  5. **"Set for Life" by Scott Trench** — Written for people starting with nothing, focused on building savings aggressively and using real estate. Directly applicable to junior veterans starting from zero.
  6. **"The Psychology of Money" by Morgan Housel** — Best book on understanding why we make the financial decisions we do. Essential reading if your spending habits don't align with your stated goals.
  7. **"A Simple Path to Wealth" by JL Collins** — The index fund investing bible. If you want a simple, reliable, long-term investing strategy that doesn't require you to be a stock picker, read this.
  8. **"Die with Zero" by Bill Perkins** — Challenges the accumulate-forever mindset. Important counterbalance for veterans who have been in deprivation mode and need permission to live intentionally while building wealth.
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## Entrepreneurship & Business

1. **"The E-Myth Revisited" by Michael E. Gerber** — The most important business book for veterans who want to start a company. The trap: working IN your business instead of ON it. Military veterans are prone to this. Read it before you start anything.
2. **"\$100M Offers" by Alex Hormozi** — How to build an offer so good people feel stupid saying no. Practical, direct, no fluff. Applies directly to service-based businesses veterans typically start.

3. **"Zero to One" by Peter Thiel** — Contrarian thinking about building businesses. Better for veterans interested in technology or creating genuinely new things, not copying existing models.
  4. **"The Lean Startup" by Eric Ries** — The methodology for testing business ideas before wasting money on them. The military analogy: recon before you commit. Essential reading before you spend a dime on a business idea.
  5. **"Buy Then Build" by Walker Deibel** — Argues that buying an existing business is better than starting one. Relevant for veterans with GI Bill money, VA loans, or SBA access who want a faster path to business ownership.
  6. **"Profit First" by Mike Michalowicz** — A cash management system for small businesses built on paying yourself first and running on what's left. Aligns with military thinking about operating under constraints.
  7. **"Traction" by Gino Wickman** — The Entrepreneurial Operating System (EOS) for running a business. Veterans who love systems and processes will find this clicks immediately.
  8. **"Never Split the Difference" by Chris Voss** — FBI hostage negotiator teaches negotiation. One of the most useful books for veterans entering civilian business environments where they didn't grow up negotiating salaries and deals.
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## Physical Health & Performance

1. **"Tactical Barbell" by K. Black** — Written specifically for military, law enforcement, and first responders. No-fluff strength programming designed for people whose fitness must coexist with a demanding operational life.
2. **"The Comfort Crisis" by Michael Easter** — Author embeds with hunters in Alaska and explores why voluntary discomfort builds resilience. Deeply relevant to veterans processing the loss of the hard, purposeful physical demands of service.
3. **"Why We Sleep" by Matthew Walker** — The most compelling case ever made for prioritizing sleep. Read this if you're still treating sleep like a weakness. Especially relevant for veterans with sleep debt and disrupted patterns.
4. **"Outlive: The Science and Art of Longevity" by Peter Attia** — The longevity framework. Focuses on the "four horsemen" of death (heart disease, cancer, diabetes, neurodegeneration) and how to proactively fight them. Critical for veterans with combat-related health conditions.
5. **"Can't Hurt Me" by David Goggins** — Former SEAL talks about mental callusing and overcoming physical and mental limits. Polarizing book. The mindset content is legitimate; use the framework, not the self-abuse.
6. **"Becoming a Supple Leopard" by Kelly Starrett** — Movement and mobility bible. Addresses the chronic pain and mechanical problems many veterans carry from years of demanding physical service. Practical and technique-focused.

7. **"The 4-Hour Body" by Tim Ferriss** — Minimum effective dose approach to body composition. Not a replacement for solid training, but the slow-carb diet and measurement framework are practically useful for veterans who want results without obsession.

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## Mental Health & Resilience (Non-Clinical, Practical)

1. **"Man's Search for Meaning" by Viktor Frankl** — Holocaust survivor and psychiatrist on finding meaning in suffering. Required reading for any veteran processing moral injury, survivor's guilt, or the transition's identity void. Nothing else quite like it.
  2. **"The Body Keeps the Score" by Bessel van der Kolk** — The definitive book on trauma and how it lives in the body. Helps veterans understand what's happening physiologically when they're reactive, numb, or hypervigilant. Clinical but accessible.
  3. **"Extreme Ownership" by Jocko Willink and Leif Babin** — Two former Navy SEALs on radical personal accountability. The mental framework here — owning everything in your life, no excuses — is directly applicable to the veteran who's stuck and blaming external circumstances.
  4. **"Mindset" by Carol Dweck** — Fixed vs. growth mindset. Valuable for veterans who've been told they're good at certain things and bad at others for their entire careers. The growth mindset framework applies to learning civilian norms and skills.
  5. **"The Obstacle Is the Way" by Ryan Holiday** — Stoic philosophy applied to modern adversity. Many veterans find Stoicism resonates with their training to perform under pressure. Holiday makes it practical and readable.
  6. **"Lost Connections" by Johann Hari** — Argues that depression and anxiety are largely caused by social and environmental factors (disconnection, lack of meaning, poverty) rather than purely brain chemistry. Relevant for veterans struggling post-separation in isolation.
  7. **"What My Mother and I Don't Talk About" — edited by Michele Filgate** — Essays on family secrets and silence. Relevant for veterans who have unspoken things with the people closest to them. Helps with language for hard conversations.
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## Leadership & Influence

1. **"Leadership and Self-Deception" by The Arbinger Institute** — The concept of being "in the box" — how we justify our own bad behavior while seeing everyone else's clearly. The most important leadership book for veterans transitioning into teams where they no longer hold positional authority.
2. **"The 21 Irrefutable Laws of Leadership" by John C. Maxwell** — The foundational leadership framework. Veteran leaders often discover their NCO Academy and OCS training covered 12 of these 21 laws. The gaps are usually in influence, intuition, and connection.

3. **"Start with Why" by Simon Sinek** — The Golden Circle framework: great leaders lead with WHY. Veterans often know what they do and how they do it — the why matters more in civilian leadership where positional authority doesn't work.
  4. **"Good to Great" by Jim Collins** — Collins' research on what separates great companies (and leaders) from merely good ones. The "Level 5 Leader" concept aligns closely with effective senior NCO and officer leadership — humble, driven, results-focused.
  5. **"Dare to Lead" by Brené Brown** — Vulnerability as a leadership asset. This one gets pushback from veterans. Read it anyway. The research is solid, and the skills — asking for help, admitting uncertainty, building psychological safety — are the exact skills military culture suppresses.
  6. **"Turn the Ship Around!" by L. David Marquet** — Former submarine commander who replaced the "leader tells, followers execute" model with leader-leader (instead of leader-follower) dynamics. Directly applicable to veterans who want to lead in civilian organizations.
  7. **"The Coaching Habit" by Michael Bungay Stanier** — Seven questions that make you a better leader and coach. Essential for veterans who default to telling people what to do instead of developing them.
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## Real Estate Investing

1. **"The Book on Rental Property Investing" by Brandon Turner** — The starter book on buy-and-hold real estate. Written simply, covers analysis, financing, finding deals, managing properties. Read this first.
2. **"The House Hacking Strategy" by Craig Curelop** — The most veteran-accessible real estate strategy in print. Buy a small multi-unit, live in one unit, rent the others. VA loan covers the no-down-payment problem. This book breaks down exactly how to do it.
3. **"Long-Distance Real Estate Investing" by David Greene** — How to invest in markets that aren't where you live. Critical for veterans who are stationed somewhere or who live in a high cost-of-living area where local investing doesn't pencil.
4. **"BRRRR" by David Greene** — The Buy, Rehab, Rent, Refinance, Repeat strategy explained in full. How to recycle your capital and grow a portfolio without infinite cash. Advanced but achievable.
5. **"The Millionaire Real Estate Investor" by Gary Keller** — The framework for building serious real estate wealth. Covers mindset, models, and methods. More comprehensive and strategic than property-by-property tactics books.
6. **"Never Split the Difference" by Chris Voss** — (Listed again intentionally.) Negotiating real estate deals is where this pays off directly. Every investor should know these techniques.
7. **"Set for Life" by Scott Trench** — (Listed again intentionally.) Covers house hacking and the savings rate required to get into your first deal. Essential groundwork before buying.

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## Career Development

1. **"What Color Is Your Parachute?" by Richard N. Bolles** — The perennial career change guide. The exercises inside — especially the Flower Exercise for identifying skills and values — are worth the price of the book alone.
  2. **"The 2-Hour Job Search" by Steve Dalton** — A methodical, efficient approach to the job search. Directly counters the spray-and-pray resume approach. Aligns with military planning thinking.
  3. **"Designing Your Life" by Bill Burnett and Dave Evans** — Stanford professors apply design thinking to career and life planning. The "Odyssey Plans" exercise (three 5-year paths) is especially valuable for veterans who don't know what they want next.
  4. **"Linchpin: Are You Indispensable?" by Seth Godin** — How to become the person an organization can't function without. Important for veterans who need to understand how civilian organizations create and recognize value.
  5. **"Give and Take" by Adam Grant** — Research on how "givers" (vs. takers and matchers) end up winning in the long run. Challenges veterans who were taught that showing vulnerability or helping others comes at a personal cost.
  6. **"The Squiggly Career" by Helen Tupper and Sarah Ellis** — For the veteran who realizes the straight-line career path isn't available or appealing. Frameworks for navigating a non-linear career with confidence.
  7. **"Negotiating Your Salary" by Jack Chapman** — Simple, direct guide to salary negotiation. Most veterans were never negotiated with — the Army just told them what they made. This book teaches the skill most veterans leave money on the table for not having.
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## PODCASTS

### Veteran-Focused

1. **"Jocko Podcast" (Jocko Willink)** — Former Navy SEAL on leadership, discipline, war history, and mindset. Long form, often 3+ hours. Dense with usable content. One of the most downloaded podcasts on earth for a reason.
2. **"Veteran on the Move" (Joe Crane)** — Veterans share stories of building businesses and navigating transition. Directly relevant to course themes. Guest-heavy — lots of different paths modeled.

3. **"From Green to Gold" (Seth Kniep)** — Veteran-to-veteran career and business transition stories. Direct interviews focused on practical advice.
  4. **"The Mission" by American Corporate Partners** — Covers veteran career development, hiring, and mentorship topics. Paired well with the ACP mentorship program.
  5. **"Travis Manion Foundation Podcast"** — Leadership, service, and legacy themes. Veterans and civilians discussing character and impact.
  6. **"The Veterans Edge" (PsychArmor)** — Focused on mental health, transition challenges, and tools for sustainable civilian life.
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## Personal Finance

1. **"ChooseFI"** — Financial independence community podcast. Heavy emphasis on index investing, frugality, and geographic arbitrage. Veterans resonate with the frugality culture and mathematical certainty of the FI approach.
  2. **"BiggerPockets Money" (Mindy Jensen & Scott Trench)** — Personal finance and wealth building, heavy on real estate. Practical and beginner-friendly.
  3. **"The Dave Ramsey Show"** — Debt elimination and basic financial planning. Best for veterans who are in crisis mode or deep in consumer debt. More conservative than the MISSION REBUILD approach but solid fundamentals.
  4. **"Planet Money" (NPR)** — Economic and financial concepts explained in story form. Helps veterans understand how macroeconomics affects their personal financial decisions.
  5. **"Afford Anything" (Paula Pant)** — The "you can afford anything but not everything" framework. Smart balance of lifestyle design and financial discipline. Especially useful for veterans who don't want to be cheap forever.
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## Entrepreneurship

1. **"How I Built This" (Guy Raz, NPR)** — Interviews with founders of major companies about how they built them. Demystifies entrepreneurship by showing the actual messy path — not the overnight success myth.
2. **"My First Million" (Sam Parr & Shaan Puri)** — Business ideas, deals, and frameworks discussed between two founders. Fast, entertaining, packed with ideas. Good for the veteran who's business-curious but doesn't know where to start.
3. **"Founder's Podcast" (David Senra)** — Deep dives into the biographies of great founders. Each episode is essentially a book summary of an entrepreneur's life. Exceptional quality.



4. **"The Tim Ferriss Show"** — Long-form interviews with world-class performers, authors, investors, and entrepreneurs. The "2 Questions" format extracts tactics and routines from elite people.
  5. **"Acquisition Entrepreneurship" (Codie Sanchez)** — Focused on buying existing businesses rather than starting from scratch. Directly relevant to veterans with capital or financing access who want to own something immediately.
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## Leadership

1. **"EntreLeadership" (Dave Ramsey team)** — Business and leadership from a values-driven perspective. Practical for veterans building teams in civilian or entrepreneurial contexts.
  2. **"WorkLife with Adam Grant"** — Organizational psychologist explores the science of making work better. Helps veterans understand how high-performing civilian organizations function and why they operate differently from the military.
  3. **"The Daily Stoic" (Ryan Holiday)** — Short daily Stoic reflections. 5–10 minutes. Excellent for veterans who want a daily mental discipline practice.
  4. **"Finding Mastery" (Dr. Michael Gervais)** — Sports psychologist interviews elite performers — athletes, military leaders, executives. Focused on peak performance psychology. Directly applicable to the veteran mindset.
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## Health & Performance

1. **"Huberman Lab" (Andrew Huberman)** — Stanford neuroscientist covers sleep, light, hormones, nutrition, exercise, stress, and more. Dense with protocol-level detail. One of the most useful podcasts available for optimizing human performance.
  2. **"Peter Attia Drive"** — MD focused on longevity, metabolic health, and optimization. Longer episodes, more clinical, extremely high-information-density. Best for veterans who want to understand the science behind their health choices.
  3. **"The Model Health Show" (Shawn Stevenson)** — Health optimization without the clinical jargon. Covers sleep, nutrition, fitness, and mindset. Accessible and practical.
  4. **"Mind Pump" (Sal Di Stefano, Adam Schafer, Justin Andrews)** — Three personal trainers talk lifting, nutrition, and evidence-based fitness. Excellent pushback against gym culture myths. Real talk about what actually works.
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## WEBSITES & ONLINE TOOLS

### VA.gov — Specific Pages

| Resource | URL | What It's For |

|---|---|---|

| VA Benefits Hub | [va.gov/benefits](https://va.gov/benefits) | Starting point for all benefits research |

| Disability Compensation | [va.gov/disability](https://va.gov/disability) | File claims, check status, understand ratings |

| GI Bill Comparison Tool | [va.gov/gi-bill-comparison-tool](https://va.gov/gi-bill-comparison-tool) | Compare schools, see BAH rates, calculate benefits |

| VA Home Loan | [va.gov/housing-assistance/home-loans](https://va.gov/housing-assistance/home-loans) | COE, lenders, eligibility |

| VA Healthcare Enrollment | [va.gov/health-care/apply](https://va.gov/health-care/apply) | Enroll in VA healthcare |

| VR&E (Chapter 31) | [va.gov/careers-employment/vocational-rehabilitation](https://va.gov/careers-employment/vocational-rehabilitation) | Voc Rehab application and info |

| PACT Act Information | [va.gov/resources/the-pact-act-and-your-va-benefits](https://va.gov/resources/the-pact-act-and-your-va-benefits) | Burn pit, toxin exposure claims |

| VA Mental Health | [va.gov/health-care/health-needs-conditions/mental-health](https://va.gov/health-care/health-needs-conditions/mental-health) | Mental health services and access |

| eBenefits | [ebenefits.va.gov](https://ebenefits.va.gov) | Legacy portal — some functions still here |

| Ask VA | [ask.va.gov](https://ask.va.gov) | Submit questions to VA directly |

| Board of Veterans Appeals | [bva.va.gov](https://bva.va.gov) | Appeals process info |

### Financial Tools

#### Budgeting & Tracking:

- **YNAB (You Need A Budget)** — [ynab.com](https://ynab.com) — The most disciplined budgeting app available. Zero-based budgeting. Free trial, then paid. Worth every penny if you actually use it.
- **Mint** — [mint.com](https://mint.com) — Free, automatic, tracks everything. Less discipline-based than YNAB. Good for a spending snapshot.
- **Personal Capital (Empower)** — [personalcapital.com](https://personalcapital.com) — Best free tool for tracking net worth, investment performance, and retirement planning. Links all accounts.
- **EveryDollar** — [everydollar.com](https://everydollar.com) — Dave Ramsey's budgeting tool. Free version is solid.

### Investment Platforms:

- **Fidelity** — fidelity.com — No minimum, no commissions, excellent index fund options. Often recommended for TSP rollover.
- **Vanguard** — vanguard.com — Home of low-cost index funds. The VTSAX "set and forget" approach.
- **M1 Finance** — m1.com — Automated investing with custom portfolio allocation. Good for veterans who want automation without full surrender of control.
- **TSP** — tsp.gov — Thrift Savings Plan. If still serving or recently separated, understand your options and the rollover process.

### Credit:

- **Credit Karma** — creditkarma.com — Free credit monitoring and score tracking. No excuse not to know your score.
- **AnnualCreditReport.com** — Federally mandated free credit reports from all three bureaus. Pull these and review for errors before any major financial move.

### Real Estate Analysis:

- **Zillow** — zillow.com — Market values, comps, listing history.
  - **Redfin** — redfin.com — More data-dense than Zillow. Better for research.
  - **BiggerPockets Rental Property Calculator** — biggerpockets.com/rental-property-calculator — Analyze deals before you buy.
  - **Mashvisor** — mashvisor.com — Data on rental income potential by neighborhood. Useful for market selection.
  - **Rentometer** — rentometer.com — Check market rents for specific property types in specific zip codes.
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## Career Platforms

### Resume Building:

- **Resume.io** — Simple, clean templates. ATS-compatible options.
- **Zety** — AI-assisted resume builder with civilian-friendly templates.
- **VMware Veteran Resume Builder** — Free tool built specifically for military-to-civilian translation.
- **O\*NET Military Crosswalk** — onetonline.org/crosswalk/MOC — Enter your MOS/rate/AFSC and get a list of civilian occupation equivalents.

### Job Boards for Veterans:

- **Hire Heroes USA** — hireheroesusa.org — Free job search assistance, resume help, and employer connections for veterans.

- **RecruitMilitary** — [recruitmilitary.com](https://recruitmilitary.com) — Veteran-specific job board and job fairs.
- **USAJobs** — [usajobs.gov](https://usajobs.gov) — Federal civilian jobs. Veterans' preference applies here — use it.
- **Hire a Veteran** — [hireaveteran.com](https://hireaveteran.com) — Aggregates veteran-friendly employers.
- **LinkedIn Jobs** — [linkedin.com/jobs](https://linkedin.com/jobs) — Filter for veteran-friendly employers. Best general-market job board.

### Salary Research:

- **Glassdoor** — [glassdoor.com](https://glassdoor.com) — Company reviews and salary data by role and market.
  - **Levels.fyi** — [levels.fyi](https://levels.fyi) — Tech industry salary data by level. Specific and reliable.
  - **Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS)** — [bls.gov/ooh](https://bls.gov/ooh) — Occupational Outlook Handbook. Salary ranges, job outlook, required education for hundreds of careers.
  - **LinkedIn Salary Insights** — [linkedin.com/salary](https://linkedin.com/salary) — Salary ranges based on real LinkedIn user data.
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## VA RESOURCES — PROGRAMS & SPECIFIC LINKS

### VA Disability Claims

**Key Program:** Compensation & Pension (C&P) Examinations

- Request all medical records before your C&P exam
- Bring a buddy statement (lay statement from someone who witnessed your condition)
- Know your diagnosis — service connection requires showing the condition exists, it occurred or was aggravated in service, and there's a nexus between the two
- File for secondary conditions — if an SC condition caused another condition, that second one is also potentially SC

**Key Tool:** VA Claims and Appeals Status — [va.gov/claim-or-appeal-status/](https://va.gov/claim-or-appeal-status/)

**Key Action:** Get a VSO to represent you at no cost before hiring a claims agent

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### VR&E — Vocational Rehabilitation & Employment (Chapter 31)

**Who's eligible:** Veterans with a service-connected disability rating of at least 10% (or found to have an employment handicap by VA)

**What it covers:**

- Tuition and fees at approved schools (can exceed GI Bill amounts)
- Books, supplies, equipment
- Subsistence allowance (monthly living stipend)
- Job training, job placement assistance
- Independent living support (for severely disabled veterans)
- Support for self-employment (business planning and seed resources)

**Apply at:** [va.gov/careers-employment/vocational-rehabilitation/apply-vre-form-28-1900/](https://va.gov/careers-employment/vocational-rehabilitation/apply-vre-form-28-1900/)

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## GI Bill — Post-9/11 (Chapter 33)

**Key facts:**

- 36 months of benefits (48 months if combining with Chapter 30)
- Covers tuition at public in-state rates (or a national maximum cap for private schools)
- Monthly housing allowance based on school ZIP code and enrollment status (full-time = full BAH for E-5 with dependents)
- \$1,000/year book stipend (pro-rated)
- Benefits expire 15 years from separation (as of current law)
- Can be transferred to spouse or dependent children (if done before separation — this deadline matters)

**VET TEC Program** — Covers technology training programs (coding bootcamps, IT certifications) without using GI Bill months. Highly underutilized.

**Yellow Ribbon Program** — Partnership with private schools to cover costs above the GI Bill cap. Search for Yellow Ribbon schools before choosing a private institution.

**Apply at:** [va.gov/education/apply-for-education-benefits/](https://va.gov/education/apply-for-education-benefits/)

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## VA Healthcare Enrollment

**Priority Groups:** 1 (highest — combat veterans, 50%+ disability) through 8 (lowest — may pay copays)

- Enroll even if you have private insurance — VA healthcare is free for SC conditions regardless of group
- Veterans with 50%+ disability rating: no copays
- OEF/OIF/OND veterans: 5 years of free healthcare from separation even without disability rating

**Apply at:** [va.gov/health-care/apply/application/](https://va.gov/health-care/apply/application/)

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## VA Home Loan

### Key benefits:

- No down payment required
- No private mortgage insurance (PMI)
- Competitive interest rates
- Funding fee waived for veterans with 10%+ disability rating
- Can be used multiple times (with remaining entitlement)
- Applies to purchase, refinance, and construction

**COE (Certificate of Eligibility)** — Apply at

[va.gov/housing-assistance/home-loans/request-coe-form-26-1880/](https://va.gov/housing-assistance/home-loans/request-coe-form-26-1880/) or have a VA-approved lender pull it for you.

**Find VA-approved lenders:** [va.gov/housing-assistance/home-loans/lenders/](https://va.gov/housing-assistance/home-loans/lenders/)

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## PACT Act (2022)

**What it is:** The Sergeant First Class Heath Robinson Honoring our Promise to Address Comprehensive Toxics (PACT) Act — the largest expansion of VA benefits in decades.

### Who it helps:

- Veterans exposed to burn pits (post-9/11 era)
- Vietnam veterans exposed to Agent Orange
- Veterans exposed to radiation
- Gulf War veterans with undiagnosed illnesses

**Key change:** Presumptive conditions — veterans no longer have to prove their condition was caused by exposure, only that they were in an area where exposure occurred.

**Action step:** If you served in Southwest Asia (Iraq, Afghanistan, Kuwait, etc.) after 9/11, review the presumptive condition list immediately.

**Full info:** [va.gov/resources/the-pact-act-and-your-va-benefits/](https://va.gov/resources/the-pact-act-and-your-va-benefits/)

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## VSOs — Veterans Service Organizations

VSOs are non-profit organizations that provide free claims assistance and advocacy. Every veteran should have one.

| Organization | Best For | Website |

|---|---|---|

| **DAV (Disabled American Veterans)** | Disability claims and appeals | [dav.org](http://dav.org) |

| **American Legion** | Claims, benefits, community | [legion.org](http://legion.org) |

| **VFW (Veterans of Foreign Wars)** | Claims, legal assistance, community | [vfw.org](http://vfw.org) |

| **AMVETS** | Claims, scholarships, community | [amvets.org](http://amvets.org) |

| **PVA (Paralyzed Veterans of America)** | Catastrophic disability, spinal cord injury | [pva.org](http://pva.org) |

| **MOAA (Military Officers Assoc.)** | Officers, policy advocacy, career | [moaa.org](http://moaa.org) |

| **VVA (Vietnam Veterans of America)** | Vietnam-era veterans | [vva.org](http://vva.org) |

| **Iraq and Afghanistan Veterans of America (IAVA)** | Post-9/11 veterans | [iava.org](http://iava.org) |

| **Wounded Warrior Project** | Catastrophically injured veterans | [woundedwarriorproject.org](http://woundedwarriorproject.org) |

**How to find a VSO near you:** [va.gov/ogc/apps/accreditation/index.asp](http://va.gov/ogc/apps/accreditation/index.asp)

## VETERAN TRANSITION RESOURCES

### TAP — Transition Assistance Program

**What it is:** Mandatory pre-separation counseling that covers benefits, job search, and finances.

**The honest assessment:** TAP covers the basics but leaves most veterans underprepared for the psychological and strategic dimensions of transition. It teaches you how to write a resume, not how to rebuild an identity. Consider TAP a starting point, not the answer.

#### What TAP does well:

- Benefits overview (VA, GI Bill, healthcare)
- Basic resume and interviewing
- DD-214 and administrative separations
- DOD SkillBridge introduction

**What TAP doesn't cover:**

- Identity and purpose after service
  - Psychological dimensions of reintegration
  - Wealth-building and real estate strategies
  - The first two years of full disorientation
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**DOD SkillBridge**

**What it is:** A program that allows active-duty service members to spend up to 180 days before separation working with a civilian employer as an intern/trainee while still collecting full military pay and benefits.

**Why it matters:** The best on-ramp to civilian employment that exists. You get real civilian work experience and a reference before you ever lose a paycheck.

**Find SkillBridge opportunities:** [skillbridge.osd.mil](https://skillbridge.osd.mil)

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**American Corporate Partners (ACP)**

**What it is:** Free one-year mentoring program matching veterans with corporate professionals.

**Best for:** Veterans who want guidance navigating corporate environments or specific industries.

**Apply at:** [acp-usa.org](https://acp-usa.org)

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**Hiring Our Heroes**

**What it is:** U.S. Chamber of Commerce program connecting veterans, transitioning service members, and military spouses with civilian employment opportunities.

**Programs include:** Corporate Fellowship Program (similar to SkillBridge), job fairs, and employer connections.

**Website:** [hiringourheroes.org](https://hiringourheroes.org)

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**Student Veterans of America (SVA)**

**What it is:** National organization supporting student veterans at colleges and universities.



**Why it matters:** If you're using GI Bill, SVA chapters provide community, advocacy, and resources on campus.

**Website:** [studentveterans.org](http://studentveterans.org)

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## Team Red White & Blue (Team RWB)

**What it is:** Community-based organization focused on veteran mental and physical health through social and physical activity.

**Why it matters:** The community piece of transition is where most veterans struggle most. Team RWB chapters provide a structured way to find people who get it.

**Website:** [teamrwb.org](http://teamrwb.org)

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## The Mission Continues

**What it is:** National veteran volunteer organization using service as a tool for veteran purpose and community reintegration.

**Website:** [missioncontinues.org](http://missioncontinues.org)

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## Veterati

**What it is:** Free platform connecting veterans with mentors across industries. Over 10,000 volunteer mentors.

**Website:** [veterati.com](http://veterati.com)

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## PsychArmor Institute

**What it is:** Training and education about veteran culture for healthcare providers, employers, and educators — AND resources for veterans navigating civilian healthcare and institutions.

**Website:** [psycharmor.org](http://psycharmor.org)

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## FINANCIAL TOOLS — QUICK REFERENCE

| Tool | Use | Cost | Website |

|---|---|---|---|

| YNAB | Zero-based budgeting | ~\$14/month | [ynab.com](https://ynab.com) |

| Mint | Automatic spending tracking | Free | [mint.com](https://mint.com) |

| Personal Capital (Empower) | Net worth + investment tracking | Free | [personalcapital.com](https://personalcapital.com) |

| Credit Karma | Credit score monitoring | Free | [creditkarma.com](https://creditkarma.com) |

| AnnualCreditReport | Full credit report (all 3 bureaus) | Free | [annualcreditreport.com](https://annualcreditreport.com) |

| Fidelity | Brokerage, TSP rollover | Free trades | [fidelity.com](https://fidelity.com) |

| Vanguard | Index fund investing | Free trades | [vanguard.com](https://vanguard.com) |

| TSP | Thrift Savings Plan | Military-specific | [tsp.gov](https://tsp.gov) |

| BiggerPockets Calculator | Rental property analysis | Free/paid | [biggerpockets.com](https://biggerpockets.com) |

| Rentometer | Market rent research | Free/paid | [rentometer.com](https://rentometer.com) |

| SBA | Small business loans and resources | Free | [sba.gov](https://sba.gov) |

## CAREER TOOLS — QUICK REFERENCE

| Tool | Use | Cost | Website |

|---|---|---|---|

| O\*NET Military Crosswalk | MOS-to-civilian job translation | Free | [onetonline.org](https://onetonline.org) |

| LinkedIn | Professional networking + jobs | Free/Premium | [linkedin.com](https://linkedin.com) |

| USAJobs | Federal civilian jobs (veterans' pref.) | Free | [usajobs.gov](https://usajobs.gov) |

| RecruitMilitary | Veteran-specific job board | Free | [recruitmilitary.com](https://recruitmilitary.com) |

| Hire Heroes USA | Free veteran career assistance | Free | [hireheroesusa.org](https://hireheroesusa.org) |

| Glassdoor | Salary data, company reviews | Free | [glassdoor.com](https://glassdoor.com) |

| Bureau of Labor Statistics | Career data and salary ranges | Free | [bls.gov/ooh](https://bls.gov/ooh) |

| SkillBridge Directory | Pre-separation industry fellowships | Free | [skillbridge.osd.mil](https://skillbridge.osd.mil) |

*This resource list is a living document. Update it as you discover tools and resources that work for you. Add contact information, personal notes, and what's most useful for your specific situation.*

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## **MISSION REBUILD™ | Resource List**

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